This soup is a perfect spring starter. Try serving it topped with a splash of extra virgin olive oil and cubes of bread fried in olive oil.

fava bean soup

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 1 HOUR **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS
WITHOUT THE CROÛTONS

3 slices slightly stale bread, for croûtons
6 tbsp olive oil
3 large mild onions, sliced
1 leek, sliced
3lb 3oz (1.5kg) fava beans, shelled
4 garlic cloves, crushed
a small handful of fresh chives, chopped
4 new potatoes, peeled and chopped
salt and freshly ground black pepper
leaves from a bunch of fresh radishes

1 To make the croûtons, cut the bread into ½in (1.5cm) cubes. Heat 3 tbsp oil in a large frying pan over fairly high heat. Add the bread cubes and spread them out. Fry for a minute, then stir and turn them over. Fry for another minute. Spread the croûtons over a plate lined with paper towels. Pat with more paper towels to drain off excess oil. Set aside.

2 In a big stewing pot or flameproof casserole, heat the remaining oil over medium heat. Add the onions and leek. Soften for 10 minutes, stirring frequently.

3 Add the fava beans to the pot with the garlic, chives, and potatoes. Stir, then pour in about 3 quarts (3 liters) water. Season lightly with salt and pepper and stir in the radish leaves. Turn up the heat a little and bring to a boil, then let simmer gently for 15–20 minutes.

4 Let cool a little, then work through a food mill. Alternatively, process briefly in a blender, then press through a sieve. (If you prefer, you can omit the sieving, in which case the soup will serve 6–8 people.) Reheat until piping hot before serving, topped with the croûtons.